

Guatemala



The largest and most populous nation on the Central American isthmus, Guatemala returned to civilian rule in 1986 after 32 years of violent and repressive military rule.



GEOGRAPHY

Narrow Pacific coastal plain. Central highlands with volcanoes. Short coast on the Caribbean Sea. Tropical rainforests in the north.



CLIMATE

Tropical: hot and humid in coastal regions and north. More temperate in central highlands.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Amerindians, concentrated in the highlands, form a majority. Power, wealth, and land are controlled by *ladinos* (Westernized Amerindians and *mestizos*). Catholicism is predominant, mixed with Amerindian beliefs. A third of the population lives on less than \$2 a day. Literacy levels are low.



INSIGHT: *Guatemala, which means "land of trees," was the center of the ancient Mayan civilization*



THE ECONOMY

Coffee, sugar, and bananas are top exports. Tourism. Damage from natural disasters. Marked wealth inequalities inhibit domestic market.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Guatemala

DATE OF FORMATION: 1838

CAPITAL: Guatemala City

POPULATION: 14 million

TOTAL AREA: 42,042 sq. miles
(108,890 sq. km)

DENSITY: 335 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Quiché, Mam, Cakchiquel, Kekchí, Spanish*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 65%, Protestant 33%, other 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Amerindian 60%, Mestizo 30%, other 10%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Quetzal = 100 centavos